complexities. Through his visit, Modi aimed to counter a perceived drift in India-Russia relations, especially after Putin visited Beijing in May. India also needs to ensure that Moscow does not share sensitive military technology with Beijing.

Frank O'Donnell, Non-resident Fellow of the Stimson Center's South Asia Program, says that PM Modi's visit to Russia reflects India's ongoing effort to persuade Russia that Moscow can attain greater strategic autonomy from Beijing and avoid a close Sino-Russian partnership that locks in Russian dependence on China by partnering more closely with India. "This Indian strategic goal has new urgency given the scale and speed of the intensifying Sino-Russian partnership," he says.

A Backward Step

The announcement of the joint defence project to produce 'Mango' armour piercing shells is on the lines of the most successful India-Russia co-development project—the BrahMos supersonic missile. Other Russian joint ventures with India include producing of Kalashnikov AK203 assault rifles for the Indian army, the licensed production of advanced T-90 tanks and Sukhoi Su-30-MKI fourth-generation fighter jets, and maintenance facilities for India's MiG-29 fighter jets. They also collaborate on manufacturing the Konkurs-M anti-tank guided missile.

However, all of India's recent deals with Russia are not moving in the desired direction. Russia was supposed to deliver five S-400 air defence systems by 2024—two of those have yet to come and, after multiple assurances, Russia has promised to deliver them in 2026. Last year, New Delhi halted negotiations with Russia to acquire 10 Kamov Ka-31 airborne early warning helicopters for $520 million (Rs 4,354 crore), following uncertainties in arms supplies amid the Ukraine conflict.

In 2016, India and Russia agreed to jointly produce 200 Kamov Ka-226T light utility helicopters, but Russian manufacturer Kamov and the Indian aerospace major Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) failed to resolve their differences over transfer of technology, indigenous content and the project's total cost, which eventually led to the collapse of negotiations. Again, India planned to lease a nuclear submarine from Russia by 2025, but negotiations appear to have gone cold.

The fate of the four Talwar-class (Krivak-III/IV class) stealth frigates is particularly revealing. In October 2016, India and Russia signed an inter-governmental agreement for the procurement of the four frigates—two Russian-made ones were to be bought off the shelf and two to be jointly constructed by the Goa Shipyard Limited. But the delivery deadlines for the two frigates being built by Russia have repeatedly been missed. In August 2022, they had missed their deadline by six months, following a previous nine-month delay attributed to the Covid-19 pandemic. The anticipated delivery dates of November 2023 and April 2024 were further postponed.

Similarly, India expected to accelerate the co-production of AK-203 assault rifles by the Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited joint venture. Set up in 2019, 35,000 rifles had been delivered to the Indian Army by July 2024, out of a total order for 600,000 by the end of the decade. Accessibility of spare parts for Russian-origin equipment is a longstanding concern

RUSSIAN EQUIPMENT: MORE ENDS THAN BEGINNINGS

Some of India's top Russian origin defence platforms are going strong, while others are stalled or stuck in delivery

T-90 MAIN BATTLE TANK



Inducted: 2009 onwards

Numbers in service: 1,200

Tailored for Indian terrain with assistance from Russia and France, T-90S 'Bhishma' tanks are being produced by the Heavy Vehicles Factory (HVF) at Avadi, Tamil Nadu, under licence from Russia

SMERCH MULTIPLE ROCKET LAUNCH SYSTEMS (BM-21 & BM-30)

Inducted: 2006 onwards

Numbers: 150 BM-21 & 42 BM-30

These surface-to-surface multiple rocket launch systems gives the army's artillery regiments the power to target massed concentration of armour and troops



From 76 per cent in the 2009-13 period, Russia's share in India's arms imports dropped to 36 per cent in 2019-23, says a report from SIPRI